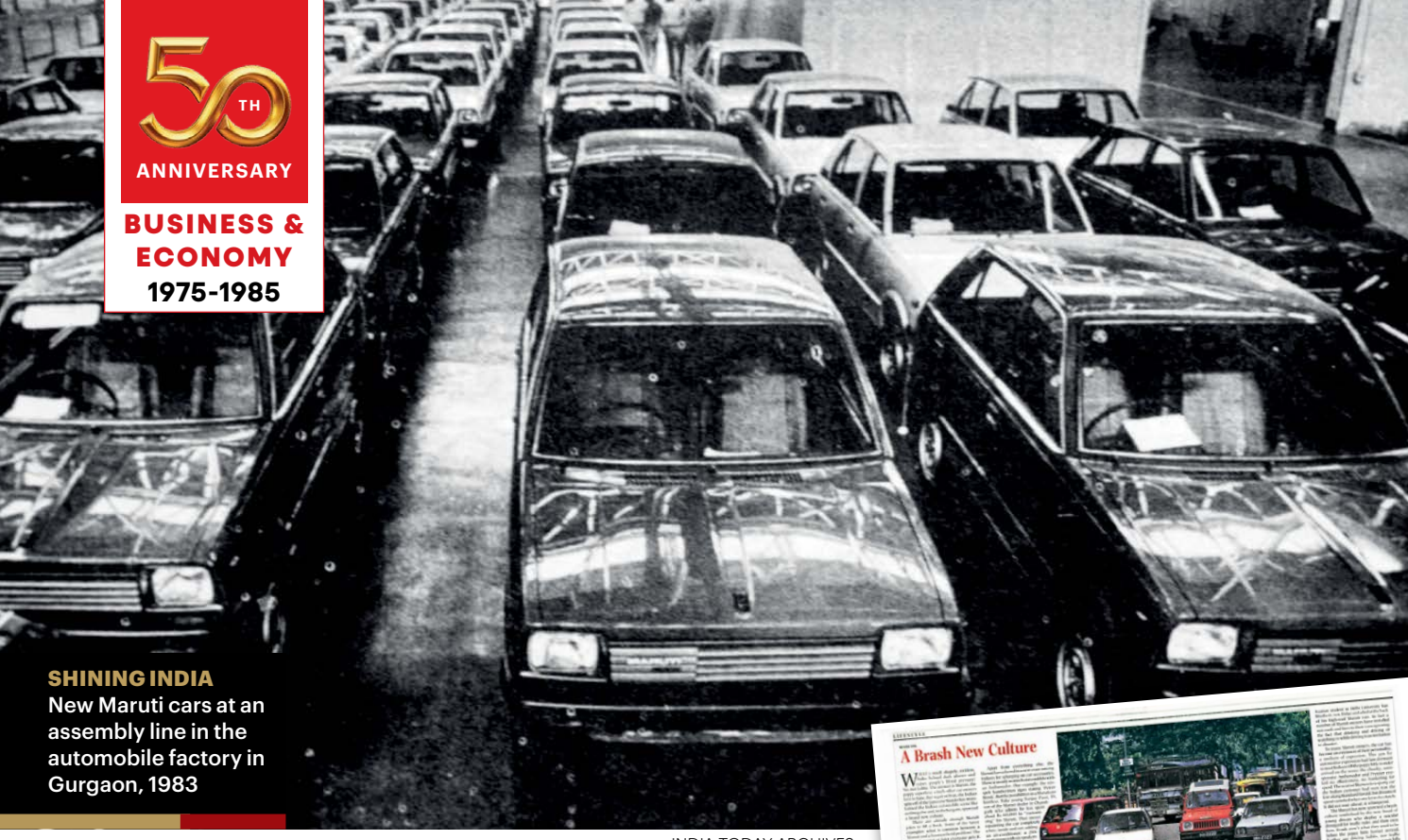


SHINING INDIA
New Maruti cars at an assembly line in the automobile factory in Gurgaon, 1983

INDIA TODAY ARCHIVES

MARUTI

SMALL CAR, BIG DRIVE

From a stalled, beleaguered dream to middle-class revolution, Maruti's improbable journey reshaped India's roads, industries and the everyman's aspirations

It began as an audacious idea in the early 1970s: a small, affordable car that could put India on wheels. Conceived as Sanjay Gandhi's pet project, Maruti Motors Limited was meant to deliver a "people's car", even though, for years, it remained, as one INDIA TODAY report put it, "still very much a pipe dream" (May 1-17, 1977). Financial troubles, political controversy and repeated false starts marked the venture's early life and, by the mid-1970s, the project seemed close to collapse.

The turning point came after Sanjay's untimely demise in a plane crash in June 1980. Maruti was nationalised and reborn as Maruti Udyog Limited. With new leadership and a clearer mandate, the company abandoned grandiose plans and partnered with Japan's Suzuki Motor Company, which brought in the technology and manufacturing discipline Indian carmakers lacked at the time.

When the first cars rolled out of the Gurgaon factory in late 1983, they were, as one report by T. N. Ninan, then executive


A Brash New Culture

A Brash New Culture
INDIA TODAY,
May 31, 1987

"The ubiquitous Maruti is becoming the forerunner of a new breed of drivers, driving habits and even life-styles. It has already established itself as the predominant status symbol of the middle class, or, more specifically, Indian Yuppies.... The Maruti has ushered in a new craze among Indians for splurging on car accessories. There was only so much one could do with an Ambassador."